Post Inferno
by Spill Major

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(*Lights up. The stage is washed in a mix of warm reds and yellows. Virgil sits alone at a bar table in one of two chairs. Dante is at the bar, picking up two drinks he has just ordered. Both are in tall, stone goblets. He walks hurriedly back to the table and sets the drinks down too quickly, almost spilling both.*)

Dante: Ha ha! Sorry, my leader, my guide! I'm feeling a bit like a Venetian on dry land today. I don't know where my feet are. Look at this, look at my hands. (*His hands are shaking*.) Only one cure for that. (*Takes a long drink*.) Won't you drink with me? (*Virgil makes no move, but only stares at Dante*.) Then, to the Lord! (*He toasts the air and drinks again*.) Vengeance is his. (*There is a long silence, as Dante sits fidgeting. Virgil still stares*.) Virgil? (*No response*.) On what does your mind dwell, my liege?

Virgil: Fools need no guide, for they are all heading to the same place.

Dante: In other words, if the cow is falling of a cliff, don't give him a map on the way down. (*drinks*) You're a real wit, my friend.

Virgil: Cows. (*He drinks*.) Wine is never as heartening as when it's served in the bag… but the beggar at the befouled puddle should not cry out for a cool spring.

Dante: (*His head falls on the table and stays there. Virgil stares off into space. Eventually Dante speaks*.) Aren't you even going to ask what's wrong?

Virgil: Even the most blundering ignoramus need not ask what he already knows, for by stooping to give the question voice, he wastes both time and thought. Let reason speak to you instead of me, and tell you that I am not one for idle chatter.

Dante: Poetry.

Virgil: I despise it.

Dante: We were just in Hell! Master, may I not have the benefit of your patience?

Virgil: If your heart's sky held its stars properly aligned, you would have no need to fear what you have seen. It would be water sliding off a heron's back.

Dante: Herons' have no pity. None for the fish, for their brethren, for the world.

Virgil: Curse not that you are asked to be steady, for your clockwork was set in motion by a higher power.

Dante: Look at these steady folk here. (*indicating audience*) These filthy, ugly, greedy, scheming sinners. They're in the gullet of the bird. All that remains for them is to be digested.

Virgil: (*He looks at the audience, says nothing*)

Dante: (*finding a different audience member for each damnation*) This one, to the boiling pitch! He's sure to feel the blood of Phlegethon in between his digits. She's to be whipped by the lover's winds, and she will be stuffed into a boiling hot kettle, there to roast like a turnip, a screaming, scorched turnip. But at least you're part of his plan, turnip. Aren't you happy about that? Aren't you thankful? That one's probably already in hell. Demon, do you hear me? Don't you have enough?

Virgil: We were not given this time to tarry and banter. The gulf of souls calls to us, and we must not miss this opportunity to cross.

Dante: Why.

Virgil: This path was shown to us by the only one who could make it. He has cut the brambles, now we must trace his mighty steps.

Dante: Why.

Virgil: What would you do with your constant questions? We have been commanded and have no choice but to follow.

Dante: Why.

Virgil: Because that is how things work, dung-puddle! God is our master and we obey. We are his creations, his toys. We serve in and for his purpose.

Dante: (*long silence*) Why.

Virgil: Go flagellate yourself.

Dante: It seems God's wisdom in you has run out. We don't have to do anything. (*he pounds the table.)* God Dammit. (*He drinks, and immediately spews sand all over the table*.) Owwww… oh that stings. Owww.

Virgil: (*Drawing his finger in a line through the sand*) Your wine turned to burning sand. For your blasphemy.

Dante: Forgive me, Lord. (*he kneels*.) I wonder… (*he touches the bottom of his foot*) I thought it would be burning hot.

Virgil: This is not hell, Dante.

Dante: We have been stuck in hundreds of years of political strife, my family cut down for blood oaths sworn over false pretenses and worthless omens, and you say this is better than hell? Men still hate each other on assumption. The place where every man thinks his friends are sinners, that is Hell.

Virgil: With one important exception. Each man believes himself a saint.

Dante: So mankind is saved by his own arrogance.

Virgil: (*rising*) Those who still walk in the grace of God deserve to be arrogant.

Dante: Those who are burning alive deserve to be pitied.

Virgil: That is where you know you were wrong.

Dante: (*sighing*) Hell was too much… what I was expecting, that's all.

Virgil: What else did you expect to see besides an exact and perfect order, working to distribute God's will and justice with a perpetual balanced momentum?

Dante: When we go to the bottom.

Virgil: Where the morning star fell.

Dante: I hoped it would be empty.

Virgil: You hoped?

Dante: I had hoped.

Virgil: You hoped. How pathetic.

Dante: No, it's not.

Virgil: It is! You are supposed to be a man of faith, and yet this shows you to deny God's spoken will even as it is laid out before you.

Dante: That is not what hope is. When God speaks I listen and take note. Now I know the true nature of Hell. But when God is silent, and his mind works in quiet symphony, I may pray, and I may hope with all the love and faith I can conjure that he shall show the infinite bounds of his mercy and grace. Otherwise, there is nothing to have faith in.

Virgil: The tricks of a mad magician are what you described to me. You are a blind fool dreaming that everything beyond your sight is gold. I'm through with you. (*He takes a*

long drink. Then he stops and lowers the cup slowly. He chews and swallows the sand which it contained.)

Dante: What?

Virgil: I have blasphemed the Lord's name.

Dante: I missed it.

Virgil: No, you didn't. When I mocked the hope of the faithful. There is no greater affront.

Dante: Oh. So I'm right?

Virgil: How embarrassing.

Dante: Your reason fell short. It happens.

Virgil: (*says nothing, draws away from Dante*)

Dante: Virgil?

Virgil: Meh.

Dante: Can we go now?

Virgil: Let's stay here.

Dante: What?

Virgil: There's no reason to go back. Come, let us sit and be merry. Let us live here, for a while.

Dante: Virgil, no. I have to finish. I see where my faculties are lacking. You have to help me understand.

Virgil: You have a profound grasp on the Lord already, more than I could ever hope… ever want for. You're done.

Dante: Who are you?

Virgil: Like you, just a poet.

Dante: Just the embodiment of human reason! Although you're giving me zilch of that right now. Why are we even here? We have to get through two whole eternal realms

before the end of Easter. It's already Saturday and you have me drinking *French* wine in a bar in wherever this is.

Virgil: Five minutes ago you were not as willing. A mind that wanders in whatever direction it fancies cannot easily find its way back home. You need to consider your destination before hitching the horses.

Dante: …Virgil?

Virgil: Yes?

Dante: Are you saying that we should forget God and just get wasted?

Virgil: Yes.

Dante: Whoa.

Virgil: I'm sick of it being smeared in my face, that because I was born before His Son, I'm somehow lesser.

Dante: Virgil, my liege, my teacher, my companion, you are so much more than me. You are the master of reason, the weaver of verse, on the level of the spinning muses and their magic words.

Virgil: The muses burn in hell with the rest of the Olympic swine.

Dante: When you put it that way…

Virgil: Go, and make a milk maid of that sweat-stained minotaur who guards the horde of men's courage and vice.

Dante: Are you saying you want another drink?

Virgil: Questions which are rightfully posed are not answered; rather, they are turned into a concordant silence, which, when wrong, is never known to be right.

Dante: I'm just going to get you a drink anyway.

Virgil: (*staring at a chip in his glass*) It's easy to find what's wrong with a world in disorder. Cracks leak and grow. Those who find the flaws in an ordered, working society are those who have the true ability to change the world. Theirs is not just a work of passion, but a pursuit of intellect.

Dante: (*returning*) I cannot believe that this foul grape-smelling sludge is what passes for whine in Gaul. I feel as though I'm drinking from the feet of the mill-turners.

Virgil: So tell me, is this quest of yours really about your love of God, or are you just looking for Beatrice, your dear departed love.

Dante: Don't bring her into this.

Virgil: You already did! You talked about her the entire time we were in hell. Oh, Beatrice died before we could be together. Oh, Beatrice and I will be reunited again in the holy kingdom. Oh, Beatrice's hair smells like unicorns and cinnamon..

Dante: Meeting her might help you. She is God's model of Love. She will bring you forth from your funk.

Virgil: She's not turning water into wine.

Dante: Better than this French swill we're drinking.

Virgil: Tell me one reason she deserves such attention.

Dante: I hold her and I feel useless, alive with one last breath in me, this is my chance: to peel everything away, thick strands of skin which have died with my lies and my hatred, my unutterably unlovable sin, to let that heavy sick flesh grow light and ephemeral to flake away in the wind. To float away by and through that hair – it floats in the air like God's one hundred arms. With her wrapped around me I feel all the possibilities of hope in the single moment; not fulfillment, but together we balance on the joyous, feverish point of all faith. Wrapped around me I feel not forgiveness – but better, the chance of forgiveness. I know: she cannot show me there is a God. She simply gives God a chance in my dark and pathetic soul.

Virgil: She's still a wench.

Dante: Question. Why didn't we meet any women in hell?

Virgil: That's unfair. We have to relate to our audience.

Dante: Men?

Virgil: Men. The educated. Same thing.

Dante: There are few women in hell, for most are victimized far more by the idiocy of men than they are dragged down by their own feminine infidelities.

Virgil: You are a fool. I am tired of leading a fool on a fool's errand.

Dante: Master, I have treated you with respect… how can you be so unreasonable?

Virgil: It is not unreasonable to refuse a foolish request; far more ignorant are those who burden themselves with the work of dunces and dolts.

Dante: That's the way it'll be.

Virgil: Yes.

Dante: So, I didn't see Aeneis while we were down there.

Virgil: Don't you dare drag him into this.

Dante: He's already conspicuous by his absence

Virgil: Not all of us have the liberty of composing epic elocutions about our *own* adventures.

Dante: My blatant self-aggrandizement is not the issue here. Let us find your spirit first. Was he buried too far beneath the coffins of flames? Perhaps your champion was creeping slowly under his coat of steel for his betrayal of the Carthaginian Queen!

Virgil: Aeneis would be in neither place.

Dante: Maybe we passed him. Maybe you just didn't draw my attention to him, or pointed out some fat Florentine who could tickle my pride while the Trojan hero slouched away.

Virgil: No. I did nothing of the sort.

Dante: Where is he? What circle?

Virgil: I don't know.

Dante: You don't?

Virgil: I've never looked.

Dante: (*leaning back, as though he has heard what he wanted*) Because you hope he isn't there.

Virgil: I hope he isn't.

Dante: He probably is.

Virgil: There's a chance.

Dante: A slim one.

Virgil: It’s a chance. It’s slim as a vestal virgin but it’s there.

Dante: I hope he isn’t there, either.

Virgil: I’ll never know.

Dante: Let’s look for him on the mountain.

Virgil: Well…

Dante: Perhaps I’ll spot him in the fringes of heaven, and shout it down to you.

Virgil: I suppose it’s worth looking.

Dante: In a minute. I feel the urge of the lord in my less than holy places.

Virgil: What does that mean?

Dante: I need to tinkle. I’ve been holding it since Malebolgia.

Virgil: (*shouting after him*) But thou has had but two drinks! Can you be so weak and weary after denying yourself for the nine circles of hell?

Dante: You know what they say. The Lord giveth and the Lord pisseth away.

(*He leaves. Virgil is left to look out into the audience, and he recalls lines of the Aeneid*.)

Virgil:

I will sing of battles, and blood, and rage,
Which princes and their people uncovered;
These haughty souls, struck with mutual hate,
In fighting fields they fought and found their fortunes
That echoed across the Tyrrhene realm,
And peaceful Italy was brought to arms.
A great number of things are born by me,
For I set in motion a greater work.

(*Virgil smiles*.)

Dante: (*Entering again*.) Ahhhhhhh…. I feel like a newly baptized schoolboy.

Virgil: Shall we be off? Let's go meet your Beatrice.

Dante: Yes, by God’s Grace, I am like newly crushed olives in the till. I see your mind has moved to view my lady more fortuitously.

Virgil: Spirits move in mysterious ways.

Dante: Indeed.